

Cold War – period of political and military tension that occurred after World War II between powers in the Western Bloc (the United States, its NATO allies and others) and powers in the Eastern Bloc (the Soviet Union and its allies in the Warsaw Pact). Historians have not fully agreed on the dates, but 1947–1991 is common. It was termed as "cold" because there was no large-scale fighting directly between the two sides. Based on the principle of mutually assured destruction, both sides developed nuclear weapons to deter the other side from attacking. So they competed against each other via espionage, propaganda, and by supporting major regional wars, known as proxy wars, in Korea, Vietnam, and Afghanistan.

### Participants

Cold War participants – the Cold War primarily consisted of competition between the Eastern Bloc and the Western Bloc. While countries and organizations explicitly aligned to one or the other are listed below, this does not include those involved in specific Cold War events, such as North Korea, South Korea, and Vietnam. It also does not include countries such as China which, while not aligned to either blocs, still played an influential part in the Cold War.

### Eastern Bloc

Eastern Bloc – the communist side of the Cold War conflict, including the Soviet Union and its satellite states in Eastern Europe. Organizations that the Soviet Union created in order to solidify its control over Eastern Europe, and which tied the Eastern Bloc together, included:

Comecon – the Council for Mutual Economic Assistance was founded in accordance with Joseph Stalin's desire to enforce Soviet domination of the lesser states of Central Europe. Initially, the Comecon served as cover for the Soviet taking of materials and equipment from the rest of the Eastern Bloc. Its members were:

Soviet Union

People's Republic of Bulgaria

Cuba

Czechoslovak Republic (Czechoslovak Socialist Republic since 1960)

Hungarian People's Republic

Laos

Mongolian People's Republic

North Korea

Polish People's Republic

People's Republic of Romania (after 1965, the Socialist Republic of Romania)

Vietnam

Warsaw Pact – defensive pact led by the Soviet Union for defense in Eastern Europe. It was the military complement to Comecon. Its members were:

Soviet Union

People's Republic of Albania

People's Republic of Bulgaria

Czechoslovak Republic (Czechoslovak Socialist Republic since 1960)

German Democratic Republic (withdrew in September 1990, before German reunification)

Hungarian People's Republic

Polish People's Republic (withdrew on January 1, 1990)

People's Republic of Romania (after 1965, the Socialist Republic of Romania)

Additionally, the Byelorussian Soviet Socialist Republic (Byelorussia) and the Ukrainian Soviet Socialist Republic (Ukraine) were represented separately in the United Nations in addition to the Soviet Union. Though not parties to the Warsaw Pact, Vietnam, North Korea, Cuba, and Laos, maintained Cold War alliances with the Eastern Bloc.

Western Bloc

Western Bloc – the United States and countries allied with it against the Soviet Union and the rest of the Eastern Bloc during the Cold War. As part of its containment policy, the United States backed a series of regional alliances:

NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization) – In the North Atlantic and Europe, NATO was formed in 1949, and its members during the Cold War were:

Belgium

Canada

Denmark

France

Iceland

Italy

Luxembourg

Netherlands

Norway

Portugal

United Kingdom

United States

Greece - Joined 1952

Turkey - Joined 1952

West Germany - Joined 1955

Spain - Joined 1982

SEATO (Southeast Asia Treaty Organization) – formed in 1954 for the collective defense of Southeast Asia, though disbanded in 1977. Its members were:

Australia

France

New Zealand

Pakistan - including modern Bangladesh

Philippines

Thailand

United Kingdom

United States

ANZUS – formed in 1952 as a form of defensive cooperation in the Pacific. Its members during the Cold War were:

Australia

New Zealand

United States

METO (Middle East Treaty Organization) – formed in 1955. Although the United States did not formally join, the country did support the alliance, aimed at containing Soviet ambitions in the Middle East. The organization was disbanded in 1979. Its members were:

Iran

Iraq - Withdrew 1959

Pakistan

Turkey

United Kingdom

Rio Pact – formed in 1947 for the collective defense of the Americas. Its members during the Cold War were:

Argentina

The Bahamas - Joined 1982

Bolivia

Brazil

Chile

Colombia

Costa Rica

Cuba - Suspended 1962

Dominican Republic

Ecuador

El Salvador

Guatemala

Haiti

Honduras

Mexico

Nicaragua

Panama

Paraguay

Peru

Trinidad and Tobago

United States

Uruguay

Venezuela

History

Timeline of events in the Cold War

Overview articles

Cold War (1947–1953)

Cold War (1953–1962)

Cold War (1962–1979)

Cold War (1979–1985)

Cold War (1985–1991)

## Beginnings

Origins of the Cold War – the Cold war was a major part of the aftermath of World War II, and was caused by frictions in the relations between the Soviet Union and the allies (United States, United Kingdom, and France) that emerged during and after the Second World War.

## Creation of organizations

Cold War organizations – throughout the Cold War a series of organizations were created to either further the goals of individual and groups of states, or to act as intermediaries in reducing the tension.

NATO - Formed 1949

Southeast Asia Treaty Organization - Formed 1954, disbanded 1977

Middle East Treaty Organization - Formed 1955, disbanded 1979

International Atomic Energy Agency - Formed 1957

Warsaw Pact - Formed 1955, disbanded 1991

Non-Aligned Movement - Formed 1961

## Key areas of competition

Nuclear arms race – competition for supremacy in nuclear warfare between the United States, the Soviet Union, and their respective allies during the Cold War.

Space Race – 20th-century competition between two Cold War rivals, the Soviet Union (USSR) and the United States (US), for supremacy in spaceflight capability. It had its origins in the missile-based nuclear arms race between the two nations that occurred following World War

II, enabled by captured German rocket technology and personnel.

Cold War espionage

Cold War propaganda

Proxy wars

## Conflicts

Conflicts related to the Cold War – there were a number of conflicts during the Cold War, and none of them escalated to direct fighting between the superpowers (which would have constituted a hot war). Some of them were:

### Proxy wars

Proxy wars of the Cold War – while the superpowers never engaged each other directly, they fought a series proxy wars throughout the period of Cold War, with one, or both sides arming or otherwise supporting one side against another.

Korean War (1950–1953) – started when North Korea invaded South Korea. The United States and their allies came to the aid of the South, while China and the Soviet Union came to the aid of the North.

Vietnam War (1955–1975) – fought primarily between North Vietnam and South Vietnam. The United States and their allies came to the aid of the South, while China, the Soviet Union and others came to the aid of the North. Fighting occurred in Vietnam, along with neighboring Laos and Cambodia.

South African Border War (1966–1989) – fought between South Africa and its allies on one side, with the Angolan government and its allies, including Cuba, on the other. During the conflict, the United States supplied South Africa and their allies.

Yom Kippur War (1973) – started when an Arab coalition led by Egypt and Syria launched a

surprise attack on Israel. Throughout the conflict the United States and the Soviet Union heavily supplied Israel and the Arab coalition, respectively.

Soviet-Afghan War (1979–1989) – fought between the Soviet Union and allied Afghan forces on one side, against the insurgent groups known as the Mujahideen. The insurgent groups received aid, and training in Pakistan and China, paid for by the United States and Arab monarchies in the Persian Gulf.

### Periods of heightened tension

US-USSR confrontations during the Cold War – while open conflict did not break out between the two superpowers during the Cold War, there were some very intense confrontations that seemed likely to trigger World War III. As the Cold War stretched on, the main concern became the possibility of a nuclear exchange—the ultimate fear characterizing East-West tensions. Some of these confrontations included:

Berlin Blockade (1948–1949) – while located wholly within the Soviet zone of Allied-occupied Germany after World War II, Berlin was not considered to be part of the Soviet zone. The major city (and former Nazi capital) was jointly occupied by the Allied powers and subdivided into four sectors. On 24 June 1948 to 12 May 1949, the Soviet Union blocked the Western Allies' railway, road, and canal access to Berlin. Not to be outdone, the Western Allies organized a massive air lift and flew up to 8,893 tons of necessities into the city each day.

Berlin Crisis of 1961 – the USSR demanded the withdrawal of NATO armed forces from West Berlin. After the West Bloc refused, the East German government put up the Berlin Wall to block traffic between the Western and Eastern sectors of Berlin.

Cuban Missile Crisis (October 16–28, 1962) – 13-day confrontation between the United States and the Soviet Union concerning Soviet ballistic missile deployment in Cuba. Along with being televised worldwide, it was the closest the Cold War came to escalating into a full-scale nuclear



war.

Able Archer 83 (1983) – NATO exercise mistaken by parts of the KGB, Politburo, and Soviet Armed Forces as cover for an attack. The USSR responded by readying its forces for war.

## Ending

End of the Cold War – While many observers state the 1989 Malta Summit was the end of the Cold War, it was December 1991 before the Presidents of the United States and the Soviet Union formally recognized the conflict's end, with the Soviet Union also being dissolved at that time. Some key events leading up to the end include:

Removal of Hungary's border fence with Austria (1989) –

Fall of the Wall (1989) –

Malta Summit (1989) –

German reunification (1990) –

Warsaw Pact dissolved (1991) – Between 1989 and 1991, Communist governments were deposed by popular uprisings in Poland, Hungary, Czechoslovakia, East Germany, Romania and Bulgaria; effectively ending the Warsaw Pact.

Dissolution of the Soviet Union (1991) –

Belavezha Accords (1991) – agreement that declared the Soviet Union effectively dissolved and established the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) in its place.

## Aftermath

Effects of the Cold War

New world order

Post–Cold War era

Cold War foreign policy and diplomacy

Superpower disengagement

Trust, but verify

Influential people

Military personnel

Stanislav Petrov

Vasily Arkhipov

National leaders

United States

Harry S. Truman – 1945–1953

Dwight D. Eisenhower – 1953–1961

John F. Kennedy – 1961–1963

Lyndon B. Johnson – 1963–1969

Richard Nixon – 1969–1974

Gerald Ford – 1974–1977

Jimmy Carter – 1977–1981

Ronald Reagan – 1981–1989

George H. W. Bush – 1989–1993

Soviet Union

Joseph Stalin – 1922–1953

Georgy Malenkov – 1953

Nikita Khrushchev – 1953–1964

Leonid Brezhnev – 1964–1982

Yuri Andropov – 1982–1984

Konstantin Chernenko – 1984–1985

Mikhail Gorbachev – 1985–1991

See also

Cold War II, for tensions that arise between Eastern and Western powers after the Cold War

Canada in the Cold War

Cold War in Asia

Cold War (TV series)

Culture during the Cold War

Danube River Conference of 1948

Finlandization

List of Soviet Union–United States summits

McCarthyism

Mutually assured destruction

Post–World War II economic expansion

Soviet Empire

Soviet espionage in the United States

Timeline of events in the Cold War

World War III

Notes

References

Further reading

Brune, Lester, and Richard Dean Burns. *Chronology of the Cold War: 1917–1992* (2005), : 720

pp

Tucker, Spencer, et al. eds. The Encyclopedia of the Cold War: A Political, Social, and Military History (5 vol., 2007) 1969pp

## External links

### Archives

An archive of UK civil defence material

Post-Cold War World Economy from the Dean Peter Krogh Foreign Affairs Digital Archives

CONELRAD Cold War Pop Culture Site

CBC Digital Archives – Cold War Culture: The Nuclear Fear of the 1950s and 1960s

The Cold War International History Project (CWIHP)

The Cold War Files Archived 2008-09-18 at the Wayback Machine

Documents available online regarding aerial intelligence during the Cold War, Dwight D.

Eisenhower Presidential Library

### Bibliographies

Annotated bibliography for the arms race from the Alsos Digital Library

### News

Video and audio news reports from during the cold war

### Educational Resources

Minuteman Missile National Historic Site: Protecting a Legacy of the Cold War, a National Park

Service Teaching with Historic Places (TwHP) lesson plan

Electronic Briefing Books at the National Security Archive, George Washington University